



A Society for Promotion of Inclusive and Relevant Education

OFFICE PROCEDURES AND STAFF CONDUCT RULES

This office manual has been prepared to support transparency in ASPIRE human resource operations, predictability in the functioning of organisational systems, and encourage professionalism and accountability among its staff members. ASPIRE seeks to evolve a work culture that becomes a benchmark for organisations engaged in developmental work in the non-governmental sector in India. Towards that end this manual lays down office procedure and staff conduct rules, as well as some practices that every ASPIRE employee should be aware of and follow in the context of his/her work at ASPIRE and its adjunct organisations.

I. Working Hours

All regular staff members (employees) are to attend office for at least 8 hours (including a lunch break of half an hour) on all working days throughout the year. The reporting time at office may vary between 8 AM to 1 PM as per the individual job responsibilities (different for regular office staff members and volunteers). A staff member may opt for flexible working hours, subject to 8 hours of work per day, with the approval of the Director/Project Director by selecting any of the following timings:

1. 08.00 AM to 04:00 PM
2. 08:30 AM to 04:30PM
3. 09:00 AM to 05:00 PM
4. 09:30 AM to 05:30 PM
5. 10:00 AM to 06:00 PM
6. 10:30 AM to 06:30 PM

II. Attendance in office

1. It is in the interest of the organisation that all the staff members adhere to the office timings as applicable and be in the office as per their designated time.
2. They are required to sign the attendance register when they report at the office and at the time of leaving the office, at the end of the work day.



3. In the event a staff member is unable to report at the office on time on account of illness (self or his/her family member), weather or traffic related issues etc., he/she is required to inform the Director / Program Director / Finance and Admin Head (F&AH) about the same. Likewise, any staff member who needs to leave office early may do so after informing the designated authority as mentioned above.
4. Half day leave is permitted with prior sanction of the Director / Program Director / Team Leader, for the pre-lunch or post-lunch session of a work day.
5. In exceptional circumstances, the Director / Program director may permit a staff member to work from home on a working day, which would then (based on approval of the Director) not be considered as a leave for the concerned staff member. However, this facility of working from home can be availed only in exceptional circumstances and the F&AH has to be kept informed of permission obtained by the staff member.

III. Holidays

Sundays will be the weekly holiday. Other holidays to be notified by the organisation are to be selected from the list of gazetted holidays declared by the Govt. of India every year. This list of holidays, including 3 mandatory National Holidays, is to be shared with the staff member at the beginning of each fiscal year.

IV. Leave

A regular staff member of ASPIRE is entitled to 1 leave per month during his/her probation period. The leave gets carried forward if not taken during that month, but gets lapses at the end of the current financial year. On confirmation, the staff member is entitled to leaves as per the policy of the organisation.

V. Leave Policy

1. On the completion of the probation period, a regular staff member of ASPIRE is entitled to 1 Casual Leave per month and 15 Earned Leaves for one year of service (6 Medical leaves and 9 Privileged leaves) on pro-rata basis over 12 months and at the discretion of the designated authority.



2. A full time consultant with ASPIRE is entitled to 10 Earned Leaves for one year of service (6 Medical leaves and 4 Privileged leaves) on pro-rata basis over 12 months at the discretion of the designated authority.
3. While medical leaves can be availed by a staff member without prior approval, casual leaves and other privileged leaves can only be availed with the prior permission through an e-mail to the Director / Program Director with a copy marked to the F&AH.
4. The Director / Program Director also need to inform the H.R for the leave they avail.
5. The above mentioned leaves (15 for regular staff member and 10 for the full time consultants) are meant to be 'paid leaves'. All other leave exceeding that limit availed by a staff member during a year (i.e. divided over 12 months period on pro-rata basis) is to be considered as 'leave without pay', with the concerned salary/consultancy fee to be accordingly adjusted. Leaves without pay require prior approval of the Director / Program Director / Team leader.
6. All declared holidays (excluding Sundays) falling in between the duration of a leave availed by a staff member will be excluded from the total leave entitlement.
7. Compensatory leaves can be availed with the prior permission from the designated authority, if the concerned staff has worked on any holiday.
8. "Work from Home" option is allowed with approval of designated authority in case of any urgency/unavoidable situations, but it can be allowed only once in an interval of 2 months.

VI. Inward and Outward Correspondence

All correspondence received by ASPIRE are to be acknowledged or replied suitably and promptly as per the guidelines specified.

- The designated H.R. staff member is responsible for appropriate handling and recording of the inward and outward movement of all mails addressed to ASPIRE either by post or by courier or by hand delivery.



- It is mandatory for all staff members to respond to the internal correspondence (originating within ASPIRE) received by them at the earliest either by post or, by e-mail or by Fax (as required).

VII. Team Meetings

Team meetings are to be normally held twice every month, unless otherwise specified. All staff members are to attend these meetings. The team leader is responsible for convening the meetings, preparing and circulating the agenda and keeping record of the meetings.

VIII. Other Guidelines for Staff Members

1. Staff members are to follow the guidelines and conduct rules elaborated in this Manual.
2. Staff members must observe their contract of employment in all respects. This includes meeting the terms and conditions referred to in the appointment / offer letter and performing effectively the duties for which they have been employed.
3. Staff members must observe office directives, procedures, instructions and policy statements and respect the confidentiality of the organization.
4. No staff member is allowed to take the original copies of any finance and administration related documents / papers outside the office, unless it has been authorised by the Director/ Program Director / Fin. & H.R.
5. No discrimination of any kind by any staff member will be tolerated in their professional or in the personal conduct at ASPIRE. All the staff members are to be treated equally.
6. Smoking and consumption of alcohol is prohibited in the office premises, in accordance with the government law to this effect.

IX. Performance Appraisal

Every staff member's performance will be evaluated on a quarterly basis on certain agreed parameters and a record of the same will be maintained by the respective Team leaders / Program Director / Director/H.R.



Objectives of Performance Appraisal in ASPIRE

1. To assess how a staff member has been able to carry out the assigned tasks on the basis of and taking into account the relevant parameters.
2. To help identify the strengths and weaknesses of a staff member, to assess the challenges faced and suggest possible remedial steps.
3. To identify the requirement for any additional support (from the organisation) to enhance a staff member's performance.
4. To assess a staff member's growth in terms of enhancement of knowledge, skills and expertise.
5. To assess a staff member's contribution towards the performance of the team and the organisation and how well it serves the core objectives of ASPIRE.

Performance Appraisal Process

Performance Appraisal of all staff members is to be conducted at the end of the probation period, and subsequently on completion of every 12 months of service.

Step 1: A staff member is to start a self-appraisal process, assessing her / his performance and duly filling out the appraisal form.

Step 2: The staff member concerned will then have a meeting with his/ her immediate supervisor, who is to give his/ her comments on the appraisal form.

Note: If the staff member being appraised and the supervisor agree, their joint assessment is to be considered. In case of differences, they are expected to have a discussion to explain their positions. If the disagreement persists, they are to give their respective explanations in writing.

Step 3: The appraisal is then to be reviewed by the Director /H.R./Project Director, their comments incorporated, and if there is still no agreement, they will have discussions with both the staff member and the supervisor before finalising the assessment.

Performance Parameters

1. Quality of Work
2. Timely completion of assigned task
3. Initiative
4. Communication



5. Inter-personal relations within the office
6. Contribution to the overall performance of the organization

X. Annual Increments, Training and Career Mobility

All regular staff members, subject to meeting a performance benchmark, will be entitled to an annual increment in salary, which is to be decided in accordance with the criteria laid out in that regard from time to time. ASPIRE will encourage and support career mobility within (based on performance) and outside its organisation. A separate training and capacity building policy of the organisation is to be adopted and implemented.

XI. Grievance Redress Procedure

Staff members (regular staff member/consultant or a group of staff members) who wish to express any grievance while working at ASPIRE, are to raise it with the team leader/ Program Director (provided they are not a party to the grievance).

1. If the issue is beyond the scope of the designated authority, it is to be brought to the notice of the Director.
2. If the Director is a party to the issue, then the Board Members are to be approached to address the issue, but under normal circumstances, no staff member is to directly approach a Board Member without a prior consultation with the Director.
3. Team leaders are required to help new members overcome any initial difficulties by ensuring adequate information and briefing is provided to them and a sympathetic approach is followed in the resolution of the problems, if any.

XII. Modality for Disciplinary Action for the Misconduct by Staff Member:

Any issue of misconduct by any staff member is to be first addressed through informal discussions at the level of team leader / Programme Director/Director/H.R. before taking recourse to formal disciplinary action.

1. The team leader is to have a discussion with the concerned staff member(s) where the nature of the misconduct is to be made clear and explanations sought from them.



2. When a formal disciplinary action is unavoidable, the team leader is to promptly establish and record facts and take necessary action.
3. The staff member concerned is to be:
 - a) Informed of the complaint against him / her.
 - b) Advised of his / her right to be accompanied by a person of his / her choice in the discussions.
 - c) Informed of his / her right to appeal against any proposed disciplinary action.
 - d) A written record of investigation and meetings in this regard must be kept by the team leader and documented properly.
 - e) The staff member concerned should be given adequate opportunity and encouraged to state his or her case.
 - f) The team leader will recommend appropriate action to the Director, who will take the final decision with regard to disciplinary action, which could consist one or more of the following: verbal warning, securing written explanation, formal reprimand, withholding future increments, forced leave without pay, termination of service.
4. The seriousness and nature of the misconduct and the concerned staff member's previous employment record is to be kept in mind while determining the severity of action to be taken by the Director.
5. Disciplinary action is clearly a serious action and the following examples are meant to provide a general understanding on the issue; but they do not and cannot cover every possible circumstance that leads to any such action.
 - Persistent failure to comply with instructions by any staff member/s despite earlier warnings.
 - Theft/ unauthorized use of the office property, theft of a property of any fellow staff member while on duty, serious negligence or deliberate misuse of office property etc.
 - Fraud/ any intended dishonesty like producing false expense vouchers, bills etc.
 - Unauthorised disclosure of confidential information, which may / may not damage ASPIRE's interests.



- Gender-based, Caste-based, racial/ethnic/religious discrimination or harassment.
- Use of any alcohol or drugs during office hours.
- Physical assault on any staff member / anyone within office premises.
- Persistent absence from office without any due cause.

NOTE: A Sexual Harassment Committee as per the Supreme Court Directive is to be formed for safeguarding all the women employees against sexual harassment in the work place.

XIII. Organisation's Books, Reports and Other Documents

The F&AH is responsible for ensuring annual stock taking and maintaining a proper detailed record of the same on a regular basis.

Office Stationary

- The F&AH is responsible for maintaining stationary and office equipment and all purchases.
- The issue of the stationery and office equipment is to be recorded in the Stock Register to ensure proper accounting.
- F&AH is required to carry out quarterly stocktaking and prepare a report on stationary purchased and used.

XIV. Security of the Office Premises:

The last staff member to leave the office is to ensure the following

- All appliances running on electricity are switched off;
- All water taps are closed ;
- All windows and doors are closed;
- The main door is locked ;
- The UPS, telephone battery etc. are left on.

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STAFF MEMBER REIMBURSEMENT AND ADVANCES

I. Staff Member Reimbursement against Expenses

Any expense incurred by a staff member in the course of discharging official duties is to be submitted to the Finance Dept. after it has been approved or recommended (in writing/via e-mail/through signed forms) by the designated authority (Director / Project Director).

Steps to be followed for Reimbursement of Expenses

1. Preparation of expenses claim (in prescribed **Expenses Claim Form**).
2. Attach all supporting bills and documents with the form.
3. Add notes if there is a need to mention some specific details about any particular expense.
4. Put up the claim form with all supporting documents attached, to the designated authority for approval.
5. After approval the claim is to be sent to the F&A for disbursal.
6. After proper verification of the documents, the F&AH settles the claim.

II. Advance

In case an employee needs advance for any activity / tour, the requisition for the same should come through proper channel i.e. with the recommendation (in written / via e-mail / through signed forms) of the Director / Project Director.

Steps to be followed for taking Advance by Staff Member

1. Fill up the **Advance Requisition Form** (in prescribed format).
2. Put up the Form duly filled to the Director / Project Director for approval.
3. After approval forward the request to the F&AH for verification and payment.

Rules

- a) If advance needed is more than Rs.5,000/-, the staff member / employee needs to send the requisition at least 5 days in advance.
- b) Advance against salary approval is at the sole discretion of the Director/ Project Director.
- c) No staff member can approve their own Expenditures / Advances. It means the approving authority must be different from the requesting authority i.e.



all staff members should get their approval for Advances / Expenses approved by the Director / Project Director. The Project Director should get his / her approval from the Director. In case of the Director, he/ she should send his/her requisition to the F&AH with details, but the later can inform him/ her about the discrepancies (if any in the requisition) as per the defined accounting rules.

- d) No payments should be made without obtaining the necessary approval of the designated authorities. All payments must have appropriate supporting documents attached. In cases where bills are not available, the discretion lies with the Director / Project Director to approve those.

III. Use of Personal Credit cards for Official purposes

- a) Under normal circumstances, the use of personal Credit Cards for official purposes is to be discouraged.
- b) But in case it is required due to the urgency of the situation, any payments against such use will be cleared only after appropriate supporting documents are produced and approved as per procedure.



TRAVEL ON OFFICIAL WORK

The purpose of Travel Policy is to ensure that:

1. All travels, local or outstation, is adequately planned for in advance.
2. All travel expenses should be properly authorized for official businesses and are at the current rates.
3. All travel advances are properly and completely accounted for before they are expensed; and
4. All donor requirements, if any, relating to domestic travel is to be adhered to.

I. Travel Procedures

Step1: Prior approval for any intended travel by staff member must be obtained from the authorized person only.

Step 2: All the bills regarding Advance / Reimbursement for tour/travel related to official work is to be provided to the Admin & Finance unit.

Step 3: Admin. & Finance Unit has to ensure that all requirements of the Project agreements are being adhered to before any payments for travels are made and makes the payment after being approved by the Director / Project Director.

II. Travel on official work: Local Travel

1. When a staff member as per the suggestion of the Director / Project Director or based on their own assessment relating to their responsibilities in the organisation visits a place within the city limits for few hours only, it will be considered a short tour and the staff member is entitled to claim actual expenses of conveyance.
2. If up to 3 staff members are travelling within the city limits to the same place (from one place) and for the same duration, only one person should claim the taxi conveyance expenses.
3. Staff members who travel on official work on their own vehicle can be reimbursed for the fuel expenses at the pre-decided rates.

For Two Wheeler – Rs. 6 /- Km.



For Car - Rs. 10 /- Km.

4. Expenses on coming to office from one's place of residence for work and going back on daily basis will be reimbursed along with the salary as per the pre-decided limits.

III. Travel on Official Work: Outstation

1. Per diem for employees is fixed for outstation travels RS 500/-: -
Per Diem should be used to meet sundry/small expenses like Water, Tea, Laundry, tips given to any service provider etc., for which the concerned staff member will not be needed to produce bills within the fixed limit.
In case the stay as well as fooding also is borne by the office, per diem amt. Will be $\frac{1}{4}$ th i.e, Rs.125/-.
2. Staff members can claim re-imbursement for outstation travelling expenses only with the approval of the designated authority.
3. The travel dates are to be finalized before making a request for the bookings.
4. In urgent cases or unavoidable circumstances, a staff member may need to make travel arrangements / bookings on their own.
5. For seeking advance related to official travel, the estimated expenditure is to be calculated at least 4/5 days prior to the scheduled date of travel, filled in the advance request form and submit to the F&AH after receiving the approval.
6. Travel expense bills are to be submitted within 10 working days from the date of return to the office.
7. If a travel advance has been taken, staff members must return the unspent portion of the advance amount at the time of submission of bills.
8. Any fresh request for travel advances is not to be allowed until earlier advances are settled.
9. All expenses incurred during official travel should be backed up by supporting documents (i.e. bills and receipts). In case of unavailability of the bills, the concerned staff member should be able to justify the reason and secure approval from the designated authority for such expenses.
10. Staff member must attach all the supporting documents in chronological order with the expenditure claim form along with the advance request form for verification by the Finance & Account Dept.



11. Any deviation from the guidelines needs approval of the Director/ Project Director.

Note:

1. Any outstation travel, where the option of overnight Train Journey is available is to be preferred over the Air travel. In case of the non-availability of train tickets or reservations issue air travel could be opted with approval of the concerned authority.
2. The entitlement for the mode of travel for different categories of staff members is to be decided.

Supporting Documents required to be attached

1. Original Air/ Train / Bus Ticket or, invoices in case the ticket is booked through a travel agent.
2. Original bill / invoice / cash memo for expenses on hotel accommodation and taxi bookings, if any, during the tour.

Note: All the bills/ invoices submitted are to carry the signature of the staff member.

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